A-level

ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENCE

Paper 2 - Generated practice paper Set 04

Mark scheme

120 marks: Questions 1-10 (95 marks) plus one essay from Question 11 (25 marks).

Marking guidance

• Each part opens with a line in bold saying how its marks are shared out, followed by one sentence on how to mark it.
• The figure in bold at the start of a marking point is the mark that point earns. Lines indented beneath it, starting with a dash, are the detail that belongs to the same mark; a line starting **OR** is another route to it.
• **Also accept** lists other wordings and answers that earn the mark - wording never has to match these notes, only the science. **Do not credit** lists the answers that look right and earn nothing.
• Where a question asks for a fixed number of points (eg *two* reasons), credit only the first points given.
• For levels-of-response questions, determine the level from the descriptors first, then position the mark within the level using the indicative content.
• Calculations: credit correct working (method marks) even if the final answer is wrong; incorrect answers with no working score 0.

Textbook references: every question below cites the printed page numbers in R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018) from which the content is drawn, together with the AQA 7447 specification reference.

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
01.1	**2 marks per point** 2 marks for each of the 4 points below; award 1 mark where a point is only partly made. **2 EDGE:** Evolutionarily Distinct and Globally Endangered - few close relatives, often the last species of their genus / family (Bactrian camel, pygmy hippo, northern bald ibis) – loss would remove a unique branch of evolution / genes **2 Endemic:** found in only one area (often islands - Galapagos, Madagascar, Seychelles: Aldabra giant tortoise, red ruffed lemur) – if lost locally there is no population elsewhere to recolonise **2 Keystone:** disproportionately important for the structure of the community relative to its abundance - predation of dominant species, seed dispersal, habitat creation (jaguar, forest elephants keeping paths and water holes open, wolves, beavers) – losing them causes loss of many other species **2 Flagship:** high public profile (tiger, panda, elephant, orang-utan) raising funds and support that also protects the whole habitat and less charismatic species (fungi, bats, moths) **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **Endemic** → found naturally only in that one place	8

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
01.2	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** A fragmented population may consist of isolated groups each too small to be viable (resources, inbreeding) even if total numbers are large **1** A species confined to a single area (eg bonobos in one country) is vulnerable to any local change / conflict, unlike chimpanzees spread across many countries **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 28-29; AQA spec 3.1.2.3.1.	
02.1	**Marks shared** Up to 4 marks in total - share them between the 3 points below according to how completely each one is made. **up to 2 Extensive:** low inputs of energy, food and chemicals so low cost and low environmental impact – sustainable – but low yield per area and dependent on natural productivity **up to 2 Intensive:** control of all limiting factors gives very high yield and profit per area – but high inputs (fishmeal from wild fish, energy), disease and lice at high density, pollution from wastes, antibiotic / pesticide use, escapes **up to 2** Judgement depends on species, market and site **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **aquaculture** → fish or shellfish farming • **sustainable** → meeting present needs without stopping future generations meeting theirs **Do not credit** • pests 'getting used to' a pesticide - the few naturally resistant individuals survive and pass the trait on • 'sustainable means it lasts a long time' - it means use that can continue without reducing what is available in future	4
02.2	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 3 points below. **1** Adults with desirable characteristics (fast growth, shape, colour) stripped of eggs and milt which are mixed for fertilisation **1** Eggs raised in aerated freshwater tanks, dead / diseased eggs removed daily – fry fed fishmeal pellets and moved through tanks as they grow **1** After 12-18 months smolts transferred to seawater cages, fed pellets until harvest at 3-5 kg **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	3

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
02.3	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 3 points below. **1** About 10% of the world's mangroves have been cleared for coastal shrimp lagoons (up to 100 ha), removing nurseries and coastal protection **1** Lagoons need water exchange to remove wastes and aeration to prevent deoxygenation as wastes decompose **1** Eyestalk ablation stimulates breeding – high densities increase disease so antibiotics / pesticides used **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **deoxygenation** → loss of dissolved oxygen from the water **Do not credit** • pests 'getting used to' a pesticide - the few naturally resistant individuals survive and pass the trait on	3
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 352-356; AQA spec 3.5.2.3.	
03.1	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Yield increases as inputs increase **1** But each extra unit of input produces a smaller increase in yield than the previous one (the curve flattens / law of diminishing returns) **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2
03.2	**Calculation** A correct final answer scores full marks on its own. If the answer is wrong, each correct step of working below earns its mark. **1 Second unit:** 70 - 50 = 20 units **1 Fifth unit:** 94 - 90 = 4 units **Also accept** • The correct answer however it is set out, including a different but valid method. • An answer carried forward from an earlier incorrect step (error carried forward). • An answer rounded to 2 or more significant figures, and the answer written as a fraction, decimal or percentage where the question does not specify. • The value alone - the unit (units) is already printed on the answer line. **Do not credit** • A bare wrong answer with no working.	2
03.3	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** The first units of input on each area give the largest yield increases **1** Concentrating inputs means later units add very little, whereas the same inputs spread thinly all work at the steep part of the curve **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
03.4	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Some areas have much greater potential productivity so investment there is sensible **1** Affluent societies can afford to buy more inputs while poorer communities that would benefit most cannot afford them (economic reasons) **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2
03.5	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Yield per unit area is very high because of large inputs **1** But the extra yield per unit of input is small, so efficiency (yield per unit input / energy ratio) is low **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 324-325; AQA spec 3.5.1.2.	
04.1	**Correct answer only** 1 mark for the correct option. No mark if more than one box is ticked. **1** B **Also accept** • **abiotic** → non-living / physical factors	1
04.2	**Any 4 of 5** 1 mark each for any 4 of the 5 points below, in any order, maximum 4. **1** Deforestation **1** Ploughing of grassland / expansion of farmland **1** Reservoir creation / flooding **1** Mineral extraction, especially open-cast mining **1** Urban expansion **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. **Do not credit** • Points after the first four - the question asks for four, so a list of extras cannot pick up the marks. • 'trees give us the oxygen we breathe' as the main impact - credit carbon storage, soil protection, the water cycle and habitat loss • a dam described as having no environmental impacts - flooded land, blocked fish migration, trapped sediment and methane from drowned vegetation	4
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 20-26; AQA spec 3.1.2.2.	

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
05.1	**2 marks per point** 2 marks for each of the 3 points below; award 1 mark where a point is only partly made. **2 Light:** selective felling to create clearings for plants needing high light while retaining dense canopy for shade species – clearings also give warm sand / soil for lizard eggs – leave dead wood – woodland floor plants (bluebells) grow before the canopy leafs **2 Dissolved oxygen:** narrowing a slow river increases flow and turbulence so more oxygen dissolves, suiting trout and mayfly larvae – shallow water warms quickly for egg development **2 Nutrients:** removing fertile topsoil / not fertilising allows plants of nutrient-poor soils (eg sundew on acidic nitrate-deficient soils) that cannot compete on fertile ground – dung patches add local nutrients **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **abiotic** → non-living / physical factors • **biodiversity** → the variety of life: habitat, species and genetic diversity	6
05.2	**Any 4 of 5** 1 mark each for any 4 of the 5 points below, in any order, maximum 4. **1 Food:** wildflower grasslands for seed-eating birds – providing food species **1 Control of predation:** island nest sites unreachable by foxes – trapping / culling / eradicating introduced rats (Scilly Isles - Manx shearwater and storm petrel breeding success increased) **1 Control of competitors:** removing rhododendron so wildflowers get light **1 Pollination:** a range of flowering plants with different flowering times so pollinators have food all season **1** Seed dispersal species (hippos, elephants, monkeys) conserved – control of introduced pathogens **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **biotic** → living factors / effects of other organisms **Do not credit** • Points after the first four - the question asks for four, so a list of extras cannot pick up the marks.	4
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 43-46; AQA spec 3.1.2.3.4, 3.1.3.1.	

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
06.1	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 3 points below. **1** Local people had used the area for fuelwood, timber for house building, clearings for farming, hunting and the collection of medicines and fibres, all of which protection could have stopped **1** Local people are employed as rangers, forestry workers and in ecotourism, so the forest is worth more to them standing than cleared **1** Ecotourist groups eat in local restaurants, are fed on local produce and buy locally made souvenirs, spreading the income through the community **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	3
06.2	**Any 4 of 6** 1 mark each for any 4 of the 6 points below, in any order, maximum 4. **1** Trees are only felled where other trees of the same species stand upwind of the clearing, so their seed will blow in and recolonise it **1** Small trees are left standing so that they can grow and be harvested in the future when they are larger **1** Selected large trees are left because they produce many seeds that fill the gaps left by the trees that were felled **1** No mechanical or harvesting activity takes place near rivers, because aquatic ecosystems are ecologically sensitive **1** The use of large machines is restricted because they damage the trunks and roots of the trees that are not being felled **1** Track routes are planned to avoid important trees and their roots, including rare trees and those that feed monkeys or birds, and old tracks are re-used **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **sustainable** → meeting present needs without stopping future generations meeting theirs **Do not credit** • Points after the first four - the question asks for four, so a list of extras cannot pick up the marks. • 'sustainable means it lasts a long time' - it means use that can continue without reducing what is available in future	4
06.3	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** The tag allows the timber to be tracked from the stump where it grew to its final retail destination, such as a DIY store in the UK **1** That chain of custody is the evidence the FSC needs that the wood really came from a sustainably managed forest and was not mixed with illegally logged timber **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	2

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
06.4	**Any 3 of 4** 1 mark each for any 3 of the 4 points below, in any order, maximum 3. **1 Ecotourism:** visitors pay to see the forest and its wildlife, and local businesses supply them **1** Timber confiscated from illegal loggers by the rangers is sold, and the money pays for conservation work **1** Electricity companies, airlines and individuals fund an area of forest as a carbon sequestration research project, because they want to offset atmospheric carbon dioxide **1** Lower-value species such as zericote are developed for furniture, musical instruments and carving, and small branches and offcuts are given to local artisans **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. **Do not credit** • Points after the first three - the question asks for three, so a list of extras cannot pick up the marks.	3
06.5	**Any 3 of 4** 1 mark each for any 3 of the 4 points below, in any order, maximum 3. **1** The canopy is only opened in small gaps, so the forest microclimate - shade, humidity and temperature - is maintained and shade-dependent species survive **1** The soil keeps its cover of vegetation and leaf litter, and the roots that bind it, so erosion, leaching and sedimentation of rivers are far lower **1** Seed trees and small trees remain, so the gaps are recolonised by the same species and the forest regenerates naturally without replanting **1** Habitats and food sources are left in place and the forest is not fragmented, so populations of birds and mammals are not isolated **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **leaching** → nutrients or ions washed down out of the soil / washed away by water	3
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 360-369, 386-387; AQA spec 3.5.3.3.	
07.1	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 3 points below. **1** Plants close their stomata to reduce transpiration losses **1** Closed stomata stop the absorption of carbon dioxide so photosynthesis and growth stop **1** Less water for nutrient absorption / transport and cell turgidity – severe shortage dehydrates cells and inhibits biochemical reactions **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **transpiration** → water lost as vapour from the leaves	3

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
07.2	**Marks shared** Up to 4 marks in total - share them between the 3 points below according to how completely each one is made. **up to 2** Anaerobic soil favours denitrifying bacteria and inhibits nitrifying bacteria so nitrate is lost faster than it forms – higher risk of fungal disease – root respiration inhibited **up to 2** Drainage ditches or pipes **up to 2** Deep ploughing – avoiding compaction by machinery / livestock – adding organic matter to encourage worms **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **waterlogged** → soil pores filled with water so there is no air • **denitrifying** → nitrate converted back to nitrogen gas • **nitrifying** → ammonium oxidised to nitrite and then nitrate	4
07.3	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Groundwater often contains dissolved salts – when the water evaporates from the soil the salts are left behind and accumulate **1** High soil salinity causes osmotic dehydration of roots / crop death – washing out with extra water uses more water and salinises rivers **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **salinisation** → salt building up in the soil / soil becoming salty	2
07.4	1 mark for the point below. **1** Add crushed lime (calcium carbonate / hydroxide) – low pH increases leaching, inhibits nutrient uptake and mobilises toxic aluminium and lead **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **leaching** → nutrients or ions washed down out of the soil / washed away by water	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 308-310, 313; AQA spec 3.5.1.1.	
08.1	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 3 points below. **1** Surveys monitor photosynthesis rates, biomass, soil water content and the spread of pests / diseases so inputs are applied only where needed **1** Yield mapping of different parts of a field controls fertiliser application in each area for future crops **1** This maximises yield while avoiding wastage / reducing leaching and nutrient pollution **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **leaching** → nutrients or ions washed down out of the soil / washed away by water	3

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
08.2	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Machinery, pesticides, fertilisers, improved breeds and infrastructure (transport, refrigeration) are expensive **1** They are mainly available in affluent societies – poorer farmers cannot afford the inputs **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. **Do not credit** • pests 'getting used to' a pesticide - the few naturally resistant individuals survive and pass the trait on	2
08.3	1 mark for the point below. **1** Provides an income that allows producers to afford basic rights such as water, education, health care and food **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	1
08.4	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 2 points below. **1** Nitrates are leached into water bodies used as sources of potable water **1** High nitrate levels cause blue baby syndrome (methaemoglobinaemia) and nitrates may be carcinogenic **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • **leached** → nutrients or ions washed down out of the soil / washed away by water	2
08.5	**Any 2 of 3** 1 mark each for any 2 of the 3 points below, in any order, maximum 2. **1** Anaerobic digestion by microbes in rice padi fields **1** Livestock intestines (ruminant digestion) **1** Anaerobic decay of manure / slurry **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. **Do not credit** • Points after the first two - the question asks for two, so a list of extras cannot pick up the marks.	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 329-332; AQA spec 3.5.1.3-3.5.1.4.	
09.1	**Correct answer only** 1 mark for the correct option. No mark if more than one box is ticked. **1** B **Also accept** • **biodiversity** → the variety of life: habitat, species and genetic diversity • **endemic** → found naturally only in that one place	1

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
09.2	**1 mark each** 1 mark for each of the 4 points below. **1 Rainforest:** high light, warm, wet all year, stable conditions for long periods, continuous productivity, many niches (stratification) **1 Antarctica:** very low temperatures, low precipitation, extreme seasonal light, 98% ice cover so almost no terrestrial life **1** Antarctic biodiversity is marine, supported by upwelling nutrients and the summer bloom – rainforest supports over half of terrestrial species on 10% of land **1** Both are important carbon stores / climate regulators but rainforest species are specialists vulnerable to small changes – Antarctic species adapted to extreme fluctuation **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • The converse of any point, ie the same comparison written the other way round. • **biodiversity** → the variety of life: habitat, species and genetic diversity	4
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 50-71; AQA spec 3.1.2.3.4.	

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
10.1	**Levels of response** Decide the level from the descriptors first, then use the indicative content to place the mark within that level. The points below are not a checklist. **Level 3 (7-9 marks)**: Answer is comprehensive, relevant and logically structured. Shows detailed knowledge and understanding of the relevant scientific ideas and applies them accurately to the context. Evaluation/analysis is well supported by evidence and a clear judgement or conclusion is reached. **Level 2 (4-6 marks)**: Answer is mostly relevant and shows some structure. Knowledge and understanding of relevant ideas is sound but application to the context or evaluation may be incomplete or lack detail. A judgement may be made but is not fully supported. **Level 1 (1-3 marks)**: Answer is basic, with limited structure. Some relevant knowledge is shown but there are omissions or errors. Little application to the context and little or no evaluation. **0 marks**: No relevant content. **Indicative content - a guide to placing the mark, not a checklist** • **Succession:** pioneers, seres (hydrosere, lithosere, psammosere), modification of abiotic conditions, climax communities controlled by climate – deflected succession and plagioclimaxes • **Application:** deciding whether to manage (plagioclimax habitats need grazing, mowing, burning, coppicing, pollarding continued) or leave alone (climax habitats) – habitat creation planning the stages – controlling scrub / secondary succession – understanding that new habitats change over time • **Population dynamics:** birth and death rates, density-dependent and independent factors, carrying capacity, sigmoid growth, predator-prey cycles, r- and k-selection, MSY • **Application:** setting sustainable harvest levels (fisheries, whaling, forestry) – recognising k-selected species need strict protection and recover slowly – deciding when culling is needed (deer without wolves, introduced species) or when releases / captive breeding are needed (low breeding rate) – predicting effects of reintroducing predators • Monitoring population size, distribution, survival rate and age structure to assess success – adaptation and range of tolerance guiding abiotic management • **Evaluation:** uncertainties (natural fluctuations, unknown carrying capacity) – examples (Yellowstone wolves, Scottish deer, chalk grassland) – judgement **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes. • Any accurate, relevant material that is not in the indicative content.	9
	• **succession** → the gradual change in the community over time • **abiotic** → non-living / physical factors • **deflected succession** → a community held back from its climax by human activity **Do not credit** • 'sustainable means it lasts a long time' - it means use that can continue without reducing what is available in future • captive breeding alone as conservation - credit needs reintroduction, habitat protection or genetic management as well	

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
	Model answer - Level 3 (8 marks)	
	Succession is the sequence by which pioneers colonise bare ground, modify the abiotic conditions and are replaced by later seres until a climax community controlled by climate is reached; where grazing, mowing, burning or coppicing halts it, a plagioclimax forms. This tells a conservation manager whether to intervene: chalk grassland, heathland and coppiced woodland are plagioclimaxes that disappear without continued management, whereas a climax habitat is best left alone, and habitat creation must plan the stages, control scrub and manage secondary succession.	
	Population dynamics - birth and death rates, density-dependent and independent factors, carrying capacity, sigmoid growth, predator-prey cycles and r- and k-selection - inform decisions of a different kind. Maximum sustainable yield sets harvest levels in fisheries, whaling and forestry; k-selected species that breed late and slowly need strict protection and recover slowly; culling may be justified where predators are absent, as with Scottish red deer without wolves, or where introduced species threaten natives, while the reintroduction of wolves to Yellowstone shows how restoring a predator changes vegetation through the food web. Monitoring population size, distribution, survival and age structure measures success, and knowledge of adaptation and ranges of tolerance guides how abiotic conditions are managed.	
	The limits are uncertainty: natural fluctuations, unknown carrying capacities and the difficulty of predicting how communities respond. Ecological understanding cannot remove that uncertainty, but without it conservation decisions - to manage or not, to cull or protect, how much to harvest - are guesses.	
	Weaker answer - Level 2 (5 marks)	
	Succession is when a habitat changes over time from pioneer species to a climax community. Conservationists need to understand this because some habitats like heathland will turn into woodland if they are not managed by grazing or burning. Population dynamics is about how populations grow and are limited by factors like food and predators. This helps conservation because you can work out how many animals can be taken without the population declining, and when a population needs protecting. Monitoring populations shows if conservation is working.	
	What makes the difference	
	• Level 2 explains both concepts correctly and links them to decisions, but generally; Level 3 uses the technical vocabulary (seres, plagioclimax, k-selection, MSY) with named cases (Yellowstone wolves, Scottish deer, chalk grassland).	
	• Level 3 covers more applications (habitat creation, culling introduced species, adaptation and tolerance) and evaluates the uncertainties.	
	• Structure: Level 3 gives each concept its own paragraph with the decisions it informs, then a conclusion.	

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
10.2	1 mark for the point below. **1** Any taxonomic group of organisms classified together by similarity (eg species, genus, family) **Also accept** • Any other correct, relevant point of the same kind - wording never has to match these notes.	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 72-85; AQA spec 3.1.3.	
11.1	**Explain how the physical features of the Earth and the activities of living organisms have combined to create and maintain conditions suitable for life.** **Levels of response** **Level 5 (21-25 marks)**: Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. **Level 4 (16-20 marks)**: Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. **Level 3 (11-15 marks)**: Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. **Level 2 (6-10 marks)**: Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. **Level 1 (1-5 marks)**: Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. **0 marks**: No relevant content. **Indicative content - students are not expected to cover all of these** • **Physical features:** mass / gravity retaining an atmosphere and giving pressure for liquid water – distance from the Sun and the Goldilocks zone – speed of rotation reducing temperature extremes – tilt producing seasons – magnetic field deflecting the solar wind – the Moon stabilising the orbit and producing tides • **Importance of liquid water:** solvent, transport, temperature control, anomalous expansion, high specific heat capacity, habitats, absorption of UV before the ozone layer • **Development of life:** Archaea at vents – photosynthesis – oxygen reacting with iron then accumulating – ozone layer allowing colonisation of land – aerobic organisms • **Life changing conditions:** carbon sequestration offsetting solar brightening, biogeochemical cycles, transpiration and rainfall, regulation of atmospheric gases	25

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
	• **Methods of studying past conditions:** proxy data, isotope ratios, ice cores, Mg:Ca ratios – understanding of continental drift and ocean currents • Links to current threats (climate change, ozone depletion) and a justified conclusion about the interdependence of physical and biological factors *Credit any relevant, accurate material, including points that are not listed here. Reward a clear line of argument and a supported conclusion.* **Source:** R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 5-9; AQA spec 3.1.1.	
11.2	**Discuss the extent to which the resources and services provided by other species justify the conservation of biodiversity.** **Levels of response** **Level 5 (21-25 marks)**: Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. **Level 4 (16-20 marks)**: Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. **Level 3 (11-15 marks)**: Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. **Level 2 (6-10 marks)**: Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. **Level 1 (1-5 marks)**: Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. **0 marks**: No relevant content. **Indicative content - students are not expected to cover all of these** • **Resources:** wood, fibres, oils, fuels, food – new food species (morama bean, yeheb, perennial maize, Kernza, bison, eland) and their adaptations • **Biomimetics:** wing-tip feathers, whale tubercles, shark skin, termite mounds, bird bones, gecko adhesion, burrs, lotus, spider silk • **Medicines:** poppies, cinchona, willow, yew (taxol), Mexican yam, sponges (AZT), sharks – few species yet studied – physiological research (marsupials, hippo, sponges) • **Genetic resources:** crop wild relatives, Vavilov centres, gene pools and inbreeding • **Ecosystem services:** atmospheric regulation, hydrological cycle, biogeochemical cycles, soil maintenance – interspecies relationships - food, pollination (Darwin's orchid), seed dispersal, habitat provision • **Evaluation:** economic vs intrinsic / moral arguments – services unnoticed because of dynamic equilibrium – unknown future value – justified conclusion	25

Do not write outside the box

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
	Credit any relevant, accurate material, including points that are not listed here. Reward a clear line of argument and a supported conclusion. **Source:** R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 10-19; AQA spec 3.1.2.1.	

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